

ENERGY WITH JESS

Recommended Reading List

For Regulation Courses

A curated list of books and free resources to support your understanding of emotional regulation, the nervous system, somatic work, and breathwork. Starred titles are the highest priority reads.

SUGGESTED STARTING ORDER

★ Anchored — Deb Dana

★ The Body Keeps the Score — Bessel van der Kolk

★ Emotional Agility — Susan David

★ Waking the Tiger — Peter Levine

★ Breath — James Nestor

Mindsight — Dan Siegel

The Highly Sensitive Person — Elaine Aron

★ Anchored

Deb Dana

The most accessible introduction to Polyvagal Theory that exists. Deb Dana has a gift for making complex neuroscience feel practical and warm. Start here. This is the one book to put in every student's hands.

The Polyvagal Theory in Therapy

Deb Dana

More clinical than Anchored but excellent for deepening practice knowledge. Very practical with lots of tools and language you can adapt directly.

Polyvagal Theory

Stephen Porges (original)

The primary source. Dense and academic. Read Dana first and use Porges as a reference - you don't need to read it cover to cover.

Trauma, Somatic Work + the Body

★ The Body Keeps the Score

Bessel van der Kolk

The foundational text on how trauma lives in the body. Readable, deeply researched, and paradigm-shifting. Essential reading.

★ Waking the Tiger

Peter Levine

Peter Levine is the founder of Somatic Experiencing. His most accessible book - explains the stress cycle, incomplete responses, and somatic release beautifully. The animal observation research is in here.

In an Unspoken Voice

Peter Levine

Deeper than Waking the Tiger. More detailed on the theory behind Somatic Experiencing. Read after Waking the Tiger.

Healing Trauma

Peter Levine

Shorter and more practical. Includes exercises. Good for building your somatic toolkit.

My Grandmother's Hands

Resmaa Menakem

Somatic work through the lens of racial trauma. Beautifully written and deeply important for any practitioner. Expands the understanding of how trauma is held generationally in the body.

★ Emotional Agility

Susan David

One of the best books on how to work with emotions rather than against them. Grounded in research, practical, and very readable. Perfect alongside the Emotional Regulation course.

How Emotions Are Made

Lisa Feldman Barrett

The neuroscience of emotions - challenges what we think we know. Emotions are not universal hardwired responses, they're constructed by the brain. Fascinating and will change how you talk about emotions.

The Language of Emotions

Karla McLaren

Each emotion as a messenger with information. Particularly useful for developing emotional vocabulary and the idea of emotions as guidance rather than problems.

Breath + Breathwork

★ Breath

James Nestor

Excellent, readable, science-forward look at the breath and its effect on the body and nervous system. Gives a solid physiological foundation for everything taught about breathwork.

The Oxygen Advantage

Patrick McKeown

More technical than Nestor. Focused on breathing mechanics and how chronic over-breathing affects the nervous system. Good for deepening your understanding.

Somatic Experiencing + Body Practice

Trauma and the Body

Pat Ogden

Clinical and detailed. Ogden developed Sensorimotor Psychotherapy. Dense but excellent for understanding how the body holds and processes trauma.

TRE - Trauma Release Exercises

David Berceli

The shaking practice. Berceli developed TRE specifically to complete the stress cycle. Short and practical - the YouTube videos are also excellent for understanding the practice firsthand.

Inner Child + Attachment

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★ Homecoming

John Bradshaw

The original inner child text. A little older but foundational. Bradshaw's understanding of the wounded inner child and how it drives adult patterns is as relevant as ever.

Mindsight

Dan Siegel

Siegel coined the term "window of tolerance." Highly readable - explores the brain, mind, and self in a genuinely accessible way. Very useful for understanding how regulation and integration work in the brain.

Hold Me Tight

Sue Johnson

Emotionally Focused Therapy and adult attachment. One of the best books on attachment that isn't clinical. Excellent for understanding co-regulation in relationships.

For Empaths + Highly Sensitive People

★ The Highly Sensitive Person

Elaine Aron

The foundational text. HSP research, traits, and practical guidance. Underpins much of the Empowered Empath work - read this if you haven't.

Thriving as an Empath

Judith Orloff

More accessible than Aron's book. Practical tools for empaths. Less research-heavy, more toolkit-focused.

Free Resources Worth Bookmarking

Irene Lyon — YouTube + website

Nervous system educator. Her work on trauma and the nervous system is exceptional. Very aligned with a somatic, body-led approach. Her YouTube channel is a goldmine.

Deb Dana — podcast appearances + website

Search for her podcast interviews - she explains Polyvagal Theory in the most accessible, warm way. Her website also has a lot of free resources.

The Huberman Lab Podcast — Andrew Huberman

Stanford neuroscientist. His episodes on stress, sleep, the nervous system, and emotional regulation are excellent. Key episodes: "How to Use Your Breath to Regulate Your Nervous System" and "Using Breathwork to Enhance Mood and Wellbeing."

Bessel van der Kolk — YouTube lectures

His older lectures on trauma and the body (many freely available on YouTube) are genuinely excellent and often more digestible than the book.